

MODULE 4: FIRST AID / WILDERNESS FIRST AID

4.1. MEDICAL PROTOCOLS AND ASSESSMENT (MARCH PAWS)

The manual describes wilderness first aid as different from urban first aid because evacuation may be delayed, and presents the M.A.R.C.H. P.A.W.S. hierarchy.

- **M - Massive Bleeding:** control life-threatening haemorrhage.
- **A - Airway:** assess and maintain the airway.
- **R - Respiration:** assess breathing and chest injuries.
- **C - Circulation:** assess circulation and control other bleeding.
- **H - Hypothermia / Head:** prevent heat loss and consider head injury.
- **P - Pain Management:** manage pain.
- **A - Antibiotics:** the source mentions antibiotic therapy where evacuation is delayed.
- **W - Wounds:** treat remaining wounds and burns.
- **S - Splinting:** immobilize fractures and dislocations.

4.2. WOUNDS AND BLEEDING CONTROL

Wilderness wounds are exposed to bacterial contamination. The manual outlines three main steps:

- **Bleeding control:** direct pressure with sterile gauze; severe extremity bleeding may require a tourniquet.
- **Irrigation:** flush cuts and blunt wounds with a large amount of clean, filtered and boiled water under pressure. The manual advises against pouring hydrogen peroxide or alcohol deep into wounds because of tissue damage.
- **Protection:** apply a clean dressing and change it daily or when wet.

4.3. BURNS

Degree	Clinical signs	Action described
First	Redness, pain, no blisters	Cool with clean water for 10-15 minutes; oral hydration; aloe gel.
Second	Fluid-filled blisters, severe pain, swelling	Cool with water; do not puncture blisters; apply a dry sterile non-adherent dressing.
Third	Full-thickness skin destruction; charred or pale necrotic tissue; possible lack of pain centrally	Cover with clean gauze and arrange urgent medical evacuation; avoid aggressive cooling that could cause hypothermia.

4.4. FRACTURES & SPRAINS

The manual recommends immobilizing fractures and the two adjacent joints. Improvised splints may use thick branches, a sleeping mat, or trekking poles padded with soft material. After splinting, distal circulation should be checked; loosen bindings if fingers or toes become blue or cold.

4.5. HEAT & COLD EMERGENCIES

Hypothermia is defined in the manual as a core temperature below 35°C.

- **Mild (35-33°C):** strong shivering, cold hands, faster breathing; active warming, dry clothing, warm sweet drinks.
- **Moderate (33-30°C):** shivering may stop, speech disturbance and apathy may occur; handle the casualty very gently and apply warming to the torso/groin area.
- **Severe (<30°C):** unconsciousness and very weak pulse; urgent evacuation and resuscitation if no pulse is present.

Note: This section is a translation of the uploaded manual, not a substitute for certified first-aid training or current medical guidance.